BOOKS

FAMILY DRAMAS

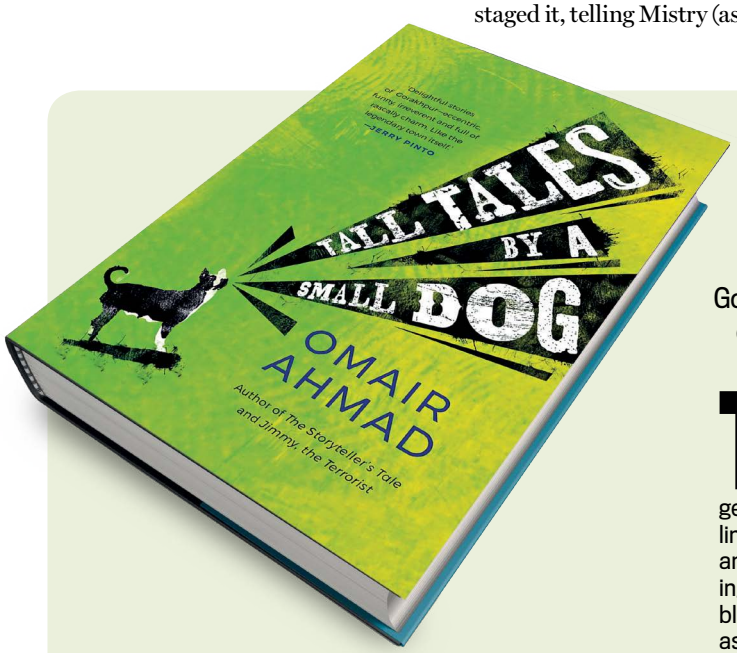
CYRUS MISTRY'S PLAYS IN *DOONGAJI HOUSE* PIVOT ON PLOT-DRIVEN CRISES AND REVELATIONS

Unlike fiction or poetry (which Indians love to compose though it gets little coverage), our original drama in English has lain in the doldrums for several years. The spark that Mahesh Dattani's 1950s-born generation ignited in the last two decades of the 20th century seems to have been snuffed out. Manjula Padmanabhan completed her last full-length play in 2015. Dattani's output has decreased since he grew more involved in screen work. Only Gowri Ramnarayan continues regularly with her lyrical classical-based scripts. Among younger dramatists, Abhishek Majumdar has attracted attention for the conservative backlash provoked by his political activism.

Against this backdrop, we consider the new book by Cyrus Mistry, born in 1956, brother of the famed Rohinton. It collects three long plays, each separated by roughly 20 years. *Doongaji House* won the Theatre Group's Sultan Padamsee Award for Playwriting in 1978, the last in that competition, but they never staged it, telling Mistry (as he recollects) that they found it "commercially unviable" unless he raised a lakh in sponsorships. Eventually premiered by Stage Two in 1990, the production may have finally encouraged Mistry to write his second play, *The Legacy of Rage*, within a couple of years (his chronology leaves us a bit uncertain) but that, too, remained unperformed until Attic Salt Theatre's site-specific enactment in 2005 on the porch of a Bandra bungalow. Mistry does not say when he scripted the third play, *A Flowering of Disorder*, which appears here for the first time, still unstaged.

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This sequence of events proves that Mistry composed without the benefits of association with a group—a handicap he acknowledges. As the first two texts date between 1977 and 1992, we notice that they apply an outdated melodramatic narrative technique no longer favoured internationally. In fact, Mistry himself comments on *Legacy*: "I had never completely been convinced...about the high emotionality of certain moments...that they could be pulled off without sounding maudlin." His style



TALL TALES BY A SMALL DOG
by Omair Ahmad
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 160 pages

BOOKS

Mofussil Men

Gorakhpur and the eccentric characters of small-town India come alive in **Omair Ahmad**'s *Tall Tales by a Small Dog*

This is a stylishly compact novel, a collection of taut time-traversing–and genuinely funny–stories linked by place, Gorakhpur, and the mysteriously alternating glint of the colours red and blue. The slim novel in India is as rare as a 90-minute film; our storytellers like to unspool in self-indulgent leisure.

Gorakhpur, we are told, has vitally touched the lives of Buddha, Mahavira, Gorakhnath, Nanak, Kabir and Akbar. The stories that follow are about less savoury characters.

The narrator is Kallu, a raconteuring street mongrel, also known as "*kamina, harami, chor*"–shades of Rushdie here? We meet a colourful cast of mofussil men: Bilal, the dog thrower of Chhote Quazipur; Jalali Sahib, "who went to his hanging and came back atop an elephant"; Knownto Sharma who picks a policeman's pocket, then